

6. Spritzers

Mix wine with plain or flavored seltzer water to make a spritzer. This stuff is great because it has no calories, no sodium, and no aspartame.

7. Gourmet cooking on the cheap

Beef bourguignon, coq au vin, champagne and wine jellies, pot roast jazzier-upper . . . it's really up to you. The point is, there is absolutely no reason to spend major bucks on wine that's just going to end up in the cooking pot. — **Myscha Theriault**

12 Affordable Ingredients That Add Gourmet Flair to Any Meal

Does the ingredient list from that snazzy Food Network dish leave you feeling a bit underpaid and overwhelmed? Are you doubtful that your local grocer will ever carry per-

simmons? Here is an expert list of a dozen common ingredients that will add some flair to your dish—for less than you'd expect.

1. Roasted garlic

I'm guilty of doctoring my garlic bread with that generic garlic salt from the dollar store. But Jeff Swedarsky, founder of DCMetroFoodTours.com, insists that you have to go fresh for the best flavor. Cut whole garlic cloves in half before oven roasting, and replace the stuff in the bottle completely. "It's a little more tame," says Jeff, "but it gives authentic gourmet flavor."

2. Greek yogurt

Jeff also suggests using this healthy alternative to sour cream. It has a richer, more complex taste, and it still looks fabulous as a topper.

3. Romaine, red leaf, and other "fancy" lettuces

Sure, the iceberg is usually what's on sale, but does that make it the best choice? Susan Palmquist, who blogs at BudgetSmartGirl.com, doesn't mind "spending an extra 20 cents for something like a romaine or red leaf. Think about what's going to be the star of the dish, what ingredient are